week of September, when the violence showed no sign of letting up, that the news antennae were aroused.

In my case, the violence literally hit home on 7 September when I was informed that Rajesh Verma, a stringer associated with IBN 7, the Hindi news network I was heading, had been shot dead while covering the clashes. A local photographer with him had also been beaten to death. At Rajesh's funeral the next day, the mood was one of sullen anger. Despite a curfew, hundreds had come out on the streets to protest. The administration has gone missing, was the universal complaint.

That night I rang up the UP chief minister, Akhilesh Yadav. He sounded suitably contrite, and promised full support to Rajesh's family. '*Hum unke family ko job aur compensation dono denge'* (We will give the family jobs and money), he assured me. I wasn't convinced. 'Akhileshji, this isn't just about money. People are being killed in Muzaffarnagar and your government is being blamed for mishandling the situation.' His answer was a classic case of passing the buck. '*Arre, aap media wale aur Opposition hamesha prashashan ko blame karte ho. Yeh danga to BJP walon ne karvaya hai'* (The media and Opposition always blame the administration. This riot has been stage-managed by the BJP).

The next morning, the army swung into action and an indefinite curfew was imposed. The violence slowly subsided. Not for the first time, the Indian state had woken up a tad too late. Too late to save the lives of innocent citizens caught in the crossfire.

The big question in the weeks and months that followed was—did the political parties of UP, especially the BJP, stoke the communal fires to derive political benefit? That BJP leaders were present at a 'maha' panchayat where a call was made to avenge the killings and to demand justice for Jat *bahu–beti*s is undeniable. That one of them, an MLA called Sangeet Som, put out a false video on Facebook showing an alleged lynching of Hindu boys is also true. At a Modi rally in Agra in November, the BJP leadership even felicitated its MLAs who had been charged with inciting violence. Two of its leaders named in the riot FIRs were given